



Harvard Summer School

HARVARD DIVISION OF CONTINUING EDUCATION

EXPO S-15

Fundamentals of Academic Writing

Harvard Summer School 2026

Full syllabus displayed to registered students only

([HarvardKey login required](#))

****This note confirms full syllabus is now displayed****

Course Information

CRN: 34243

Section Number: 1

Format: Live Attendance Web Conference

Credit Status: Undergraduate

Credit Hours: 4

Class Meetings: Tuesdays, Thursdays, June 23-August 7,
12:00pm-3:00pm

Course Description: This course is designed for students seeking preparation for EXPO E-25, which is a course required for admission to the undergraduate program at the [Harvard Extension School](#). Students review such basics of academic argument as thesis, claims, evidence, and structure. Students complete short writing assignments that help develop the skills essential for producing persuasive academic essays. Students also learn strategies for reading and analyzing complex texts.

Instructor Information & Office Hours

Janet Sylvester

Email: jsylvester@fas.harvard.edu

Course Goals / Learning Outcomes

This course is designed for students seeking preparation for EXPO 25, Introduction to Academic Writing and Critical Reading, and for students who wish to review the basics of academic argument, such as thesis-creation, use of evidence, and the structure of argument. You'll do short writing exercises that will help you develop the skills essential for producing two persuasive academic essays. You'll also learn strategies for close reading and analyzing complex texts. In this course, you'll learn how to develop your ideas and how to persuade readers that your ideas matter, and you'll learn how to do this by reading clear and lively prose written by contemporary writers about issues that matter to everyday people.

---The course is divided into two units. Each unit consists of a variety of reading and exercise assignments that culminate in the writing of an essay, both first draft and revision.

--In the first unit, you will choose one academic essay from a small selection you have close read and discussed in class. You will then develop a four-to-five-page essay with a thesis of your own about your chosen essay.

--In the second unit, you will choose one short story from a small selection you have close read and discussed in class. You will then develop a four-to five-page essay with a thesis of your own about your chosen short story.

Mode of Attendance & Participation Policy

Class meetings take place over Zoom. Select "Zoom" in the Canvas course website to join class meetings.

Because they involve active participation, discussion, and dialogue, you are expected to attend all class meetings. Please arrive on time. You should attend Zoom meetings with a functional web-camera and microphone, prepared with materials needed, to engage thoughtfully, and with your camera on. You may turn off your camera for occasional interruptions or momentarily for privacy.

You will also need the most up-to-date Zoom client installed on your computer to join class. Please participate from a safe and appropriate environment with appropriate clothing for class. Participating while traveling or in a car is not permitted. In addition, please do not join class via mobile phone or web browser.

Please be sure to review important information on [Student Responsibilities and Policies](#).

Writing Program Policies

Attendance

Because Writing Program workshops are collaborative and discussion based, your presence and active participation are essential to their success and to your growth as a writer.

While I urge you to attend all class meetings, I can excuse one absence during the Summer term. If your absences exceed this limit, I will be obliged to document them and tell you that additional absences may result in [exclusion](#) from the course or a final grade of E. The attendance rule applies even if you miss the first class meeting because you are changing

courses during the first week of the term in accordance with Division of Continuing Education rules.

Deadlines

This course is a planned sequence of writing; meeting assignment deadlines is crucial. Failing to meet deadlines may disrupt the workshop schedule and impede the course's progress. It may also result in [exclusion](#) from the course or a final grade of E.

AI Technologies

Because the work of Writing Program courses involves learning to develop, structure, revise, and edit your own text, the use of AI technologies, including generative AI tools such as ChatGPT, is strictly prohibited in this course. AI technologies may not be used in any phase of the process, including brainstorming, outlining, drafting, revising, and editing.

First-Day Writing Sample

I will ask you to complete—in person (in on-campus courses) or with your camera on (in online courses)—a brief skills-check writing sample during our first meeting. While the sample provides only a snapshot of your writing, it can help us determine if the course will be a good fit for you.

Therefore, the sample must be submitted during class, at a time I specify. It won't be graded, but I am not permitted to accept it after the deadline. If you submit the writing sample after the deadline, you must contact me to schedule a time to complete a new writing sample (in response to a different prompt) before our next meeting. Note that the Writing Program deadlines policy applies to the writing sample. Note also that if your sample suggests that you would benefit from a lower-level course, I may recommend that you drop my course.

Dual Submission

Harvard requires that all work submitted for a course be original and produced solely for that course. A writing course is an opportunity to develop your skills; submitting the same writing assignment twice for credit undermines that opportunity and may result in disciplinary action. If you wish to continue to develop an essay or story that you began in another course, you must receive written permission for your plan from your instructors.

Assignments & Grading

Assignments

Three graded exercises precede the ungraded draft and graded revision in each of the two units of the course.

Grading

The exercises, worksheets and two essays represent the bulk of your grade. Essays are weighted to reward you for improvement in a series of tasks that become progressively more demanding. Essays and exercises count toward your final grade as follows:

Exercises & Worksheets 30%

Essay 1: 30%

Essay 2: 40%

Conferences

You will meet with me at least twice during the semester on Zoom to discuss your work and progress. Conferences are most productive the week before you submit your essay draft or revision, but I welcome them at any time. We will

analyze the strengths and weaknesses of your writing and target strategies for revision. We will spend about twenty-thirty minutes, so you will need to be focused. Come to these conferences prepared to discuss your ideas and plans for revision, questions about your reading, or questions about my comments. In other words, I envision myself as a listener as much as an advisor. Have a copy on hand of your exercise or essay and the text about which you're writing.

See [Grades & Grading System](#) for additional information.

Course Materials

Everyday People: The Color of Life.

ISBN: 978-1501134944

Authors: Barker, Jennifer, editor

An anthology of short stories by contemporary writers of color

Publisher: Atria Books

Publication Date: 2018

Edition: First, paper.

Required.

They Say / I Say: The Moves That Matter in Academic Writing.

ISBN: 978-1324070139

Authors: Graff, Birkenstein, et al.

Textbook for Academic Writing. The reading section of this book also contains the essays that we'll be reading.

Publisher: Norton

Publication Date: 2024

Edition: Sixth edition, with readings, paper

You must have the edition listed above.

A Pocket Style Manual.

ISBN: 978-1319413019

Authors: Hacker and Sommers

Required writing manual

Publisher: Bedford /St. Martin's

Publication Date: 2024

Edition: 10th

Paper

Community Charter

By enrolling in courses offered by the Harvard University Division of Continuing Education (DCE), individuals agree to abide by our community standards to promote a culture of trust, cooperation, mutual understanding, and learning.

Members of the DCE community, including students, faculty, and staff, are expected to treat each other with dignity and communicate respectfully and appropriately across all channels. When using social media or other forms of communication designed to reach members of the public, no one should repeat an oral or written statement made in class in a way that would identify the person who made the statement.

Our commitment to academic integrity and excellence includes holding ourselves accountable for our actions. Violations of these community standards may result in disciplinary actions. DCE adheres to all University-wide policies that address discrimination, bullying, and harassment. Resources including the Office for Community Support, Non-Discrimination, Rights and Responsibilities (CSNDR) and the Harvard Ombuds Office are available to assist community members with concerns.

Academic Integrity Policy

You are responsible for understanding Harvard Summer School policies on [Academic Integrity](#) and how to use

sources responsibly. Violations of academic integrity are taken very seriously. Visit [Resources to Support Academic Integrity](#) and the [Harvard Guide to Using Sources](#) to review important information on academic citation rules.

Turnitin

At the instructor's discretion, this course may use Turnitin, a text-matching software that assists with plagiarism detection. By enrolling in this course, you consent to the submission of your assignments to Turnitin. Turnitin integrates with Canvas and does not require students to take additional steps to submit assignments. More information about Turnitin is available on the [Academic Integrity website](#).

Accessibility Services Policy

The Division of Continuing Education (DCE) is committed to providing an accessible academic community. The [Accessibility Services Office \(ASO\)](#) is responsible for providing accommodations to students with disabilities. Students must request accommodations or adjustments through the ASO. Instructors cannot grant accommodation requests without prior ASO approval. It is imperative to be in touch with the ASO as soon as possible to avoid delays in the provision of accommodation.

DCE takes student privacy seriously. Any medical documentation should be provided directly to the ASO if a substantial accommodation is required. If you miss class due to a short-term illness, notify your instructor and/or TA but do not include a doctor's note. Course staff will not request, accept, or review doctor's notes or other medical documentation. For more information, email accessibility@extension.harvard.edu.

Publishing or Distributing Course Materials Policy

Students may not post, publish, sell, or otherwise publicly distribute course materials without the written permission of the course instructor. Such materials include, but are not limited to, the following: lecture notes, lecture slides, video, or audio recordings, assignments, problem sets, examinations, other students' work, and answer keys. Students who sell, post, publish, or distribute course materials without written permission, whether for the purposes of soliciting answers or otherwise, may be subject to disciplinary action, up to and including requirement to withdraw. Further, students may not make video or audio recordings of class sessions for their own use without written permission of the instructor.

Canvas Access After End of Term

You may access your Canvas course website for approximately six months after the term ends. At that time, course websites are removed from your Canvas account, and you can no longer view or access course materials. **You are encouraged to download coursework and materials you wish to keep before your access expires.**

Syllabi of DCE courses you completed remain available through the [Simple Syllabus library](#) (HarvardKey login required).

Class Meeting Schedule

FUNDAMENTALS OF ACADEMIC WRITING

Reading and writing assignments must be completed by the dates listed. An "x" next to a reading assignment means that it may be found on our course site.

Note: Some aspects of this syllabus may be revised according to the particular needs of our class as the intense summer semester progresses.

ALL TIMES LISTED ARE EST.

Summer School Writing Center

Take advantage of the resources available to you through the Writing Center. Students enrolled in online courses may schedule online appointments up to one week in advance but may be limited to two tutorials per week. To request a tutorial, send an email detailing the course you are enrolled in, an explanation of the assignment, and due date to wcscheduler.fas.harvard.edu. Attach your assignment in Word (.doc or .docx). As always when seeking feedback, ask specific questions and explain your concerns about your writing. You should receive a response within 72 hours. If you are a local student, the Writing Center asks that you come for an in-person tutorial. Their website is: www.summer.harvard.edu/resources-policies/writing-center . See the Center's website for updated hours and detailed instructions for preparing for your tutorial.

EXPO S-15/ Summer 2026 jsylvester@fas.harvard.edu

Janet Sylvester

SYLLABUS

FUNDAMENTALS OF ACADEMIC WRITING

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UNIT I: ACADEMIC/NONFICTION ESSAYS

(x) indicates a “virtual handout” that you will find on our course website in Modules,

NOTE: ALL ESSAYS CAN BE FOUND IN OUR CLASS TEXTBOOK, *THEY SAY/ I SAY*, 6th EDITION, WITH READINGS.

(week 1)

June 23, Tues.

--The nature of academic writing. What’s at stake in this class.

--Policies and syllabus. (x)

--Information form. (x)

--First-Day Writing Sample for Dr. Sylvester.

--Introductions.

--Close reading and annotation. (x)

--Begin close reading of “Jobs, Crime, and Culture.” p. 658.

--DUE ON 6/23:

First-day writing sample (written in class) must be emailed to Dr. Sylvester (jsylvester@fas.harvard.edu) at a time she will stipulate during class.

June 25, Thurs.

--Six questions for rhetorical analysis/ 3 appeals.

--Preliminary discussion and analysis of Mehta's Essay, p. 658.

--Plagiarism and MLA citing (Pocket Style Manual).

--Preliminary discussion and analysis of Burwell's "Generation Stress," p. 578.

--Discussion of Exercise 1.1: Summarizing.

--DUE ON 6/25:

Close read and annotate the two assigned essays in They Say/ I Say: Meht'a "Jobs, Crime and Culture," p. 658, and Burwell's, "Generation Stress," p. 578.

Choose the essay that you want to write about in Unit 1. Outline it in a Word doc by noting the main idea in each paragraph.

--DUE ON FRI., 6/26: Completed Information Form must be uploaded to Canvas by 9:00 p.m. Read: How to write a summary: "Her Point Is: The Art of Summarizing," p. 32, in They Say/ I Say.

(week 2)

June 30, Tues.

- Further discussion of essays.**
- Discussion of Essay #1 Assignment.**
- Reading and discussion of sample essay.**
- Creating An Arguable Thesis.**
- Discussion of Exercise 1.2: Thesis/Intro Paragraph.**
- DUE ON 6/30: Exercise 1.1, Summarizing (x). Upload it as a Word doc before 6:00 PM. EST on our Canvas site. Summarize the essay you plan to write about in your eventual first draft. Re-read Mehta and Burwell essays. Read "As He Himself Puts It": The Art of Quoting, p. 47, in They Say/ I Say.**

July 2, Thurs.

- Screen sharing of Exercise 1.1: Summary.**
- Preposition Exercise/Punctuation. (x)**
- Question Sheets for Essay 1 Workshop.**
- Structuring the Body of An Essay.**
- Paragraphing and Quote Set-Up Workshop.**
- How to Write a Good Cover Letter.**
- The Academic Title.**
- Grading Criteria. (x)**
- DUE ON 7/2: Exercise 1.2: Thesis/Intro Paragraph must be uploaded to Canvas as a Word doc before 6:00 PM EST.**

Read: They Say/ I Say, "Yes/No/Okay, But...", page 59.

(week 3)

July 7, Tues.

--Exercise 1.2 Screen Shared.

--Workshop groups assigned.

--Essays exchanged.

--Grading Criteria. (X)

--Prose Style. (x)

--Metadiscourse Exercise.

--DUE ON 7/7: Essay #1 Draft (4-5 pages) and Cover Letter.

Upload to our Canvas site as a Word doc before 6:00 PM

EST. Label file: Your Last Name, Essay 1 Draft. Read: "So

What? Who Cares? Saying Why It Matters," p. 112, in They

Say/I Say.

July 9, Thurs.

WORKSHOP ON ESSAY 1

--Fix These Sentences, Quotes and Citations.

--Revising Checklist.

--In class reading and discussion of "Shitty First Drafts." (x)

--Francine Prose on Writing Clearly. (x)

--DUE ON 7/9: Worksheets 1 for each workshop partner.

Upload as a Word document to Canvas before 11:00 AM

EST. Your name, Essay 1 Worksheets. Read “What I Really Want to Say Is”: Revising Substantially,” in They Say/ I Say, p. 165.

Reminder to read Chee’s story, p. 89, and Alvar’s story, p. 157. Both can be found in our required anthology, Everyday People. Choose the story you will write about in Unit 2.

UNIT II/ SHORT STORIES AND INTERPRETATION

(week 4)

July 14, Tues.

-Discussion of Essay #2 Assignment.

--The Truth of Story.

--Tips for Reading and Writing about Literature

--In-class reading and discussion of Alexander Chee’s short story, “Mine,” in Everyday People, p. 89.

--In-class reading and discussion of Mia Alvar’s “The Kontrabida,” p. 157.

--Discussion of Exercise 2.1: Summarizing.

--DUE ON , 7/14 BY 6:00 EST: Revision of Essay #1 (4-5 pages), with cover page and cover letter must be uploaded to Canvas as a Word doc before 6:00 EST. Label file with your last name and Essay 1 Revision.

July 16, Thurs.

--Bring 3 specific questions about interpretation of your story.

--Discussion and analysis of the stories in terms of point-of-view, setting, characters, dialogue, etc.

--Work on exercises of your choice.

--Workshop Questions Essay 2 (x).

--Creating an arguable thesis about a story.

--Discussion of Exercise 2.2.

--DUE ON 7/16: Exercise 2.1: Summarizing, must be uploaded to Canvas before 6 PM EST.

(week 5)

July 21, Tues.

--Screen sharing of Exercise 2.1

--In class reading and discussion of sample essay/s.

--Making an outline.

--Exercise 2.2 in-class thesis workshop + time for revising Ex. 2.2 before uploading it.

--DUE ON 7/22: Exercise 2.2 must be uploaded to Canvas before 11:59 PM EST, 7/22.

July 23, Thurs,

--Creating an Arguable Thesis.

--Claims and Paragraphing Exercises.

--DUE 7/23: Draft thesis should be typed up and ready to screen share with the class for an in-class thesis workshop.

(week 6)

--DUE ON MONDAY, 7//27: Draft of Essay 2 (4-5 pages), with cover letter, must be uploaded to Canvas no later than NOON EST.

July 28, Tues.

--LIBRARIAN VISIT: BRIEF INTRO TO USING HARVARD'S LIBRARIES ONLINE

--Workshop Groups Assigned.

--In-class Worksheets.

--Exercises.

July 30, Thurs.

--WORKSHOP ON ESSAY #2

--Fix These Sentences and Quotes.

-- DUE ON 7/30: Worksheets for each of your workshop members must be uploaded as one document to Canvas no later than 11:00 AM EST. Label: Your last name, Worksheets 2.

(week 7)

Aug. 4, Tues.

--In-class Revision Time & Questions.

--Exercises of Your Choice.

--The Thesis/ Claims Relationship

Aug 6, Thurs.

**-- LAST CLASS: FURTHER REVISION TIME. CLASS
READING AND DISCUSSION (BOOKS, FILMS, GAMES).**

**--DUE ON FRIDAY, AUG. 7TH: REVISION OF ESSAY # 2 (4-5
PAGES), WITH COVER PAGE AND COVER LETTER, MUST
BE UPLOADED TO CANVAS BEFORE 5:00 PM EST. LABEL
FILE: YOUR LAST NAME, ESSAY 2 REVISION.**

Happy Trails!